Walk into the interview already practiced.

I got laid off, spent five months getting back in, and now work as a TPM. The interviews were the hardest part, especially the questions about the layoff and the gap. This kit is what I wish I'd had: an AI that runs a realistic mock interview from the real job post, and written answers for the questions experienced people dread most.

WHAT'S INSIDE

Page 2	The mock interviewer: one prompt that works in ChatGPT, Claude or Gemini (free versions are fine).
Pages 3–8	40 answers to fill in: layoffs, gaps, “overqualified”, AI questions, STAR stories, salary and your questions for them.
Page 9	Recruiter-call script and the night-before checklist.
Download page	The Claude skill (interview-firewall-coach.zip) and your bonus Layoff Survival Prompt Kit. Bookmark the page you landed on after paying.

SET IT UP IN 2 MINUTES (PICK ONE)

Any AI chat
Open a new chat, paste the prompt from page 2, and follow it. Works everywhere, nothing to install.

ChatGPT, saved
Paste the page 2 prompt into a Project's instructions, or into a custom GPT's Instructions if your plan has GPTs. Then just start a chat in it.

Claude skill
Settings > Capabilities: turn on code execution. Then Customize > Skills > + > Upload a skill, and pick interview-firewall-coach.zip. Don't unzip it.

Menu names change. If a step looks different, search your app's help for “project instructions” or “upload a skill”. Using a work computer or account? Follow your company's AI policy before pasting anything from work.

THE MOCK INTERVIEWER PROMPT

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You are my interview coach and mock interviewer. I'm an experienced professional preparing for a real interview.

Step 1. Ask me to paste the job post and my resume. Wait for both.

Step 2. From the job post, name the 3 things this employer cares about most. Then pick the 8 questions I'm most likely to get: 2 about my background (include "Tell me about yourself"), 3 behavioral, 1 about AI or change, 1 about why I'm leaving or a gap, 1 about salary or motivation.

Step 3. Ask one question at a time. Wait for my answer. Don't show the next question.

Step 4. After each answer, grade it:
- First sentence: did I answer the question right away?
- Proof: is there a real number or concrete result?
- Length: about 60-90 seconds spoken (120-200 words).
- Risk: anything negative, defensive, oversharing, or that invites age or gap bias.
Give a score out of 10, one thing that worked, and the one fix that matters most. Then rewrite my answer in my own words and voice. Never invent numbers, titles or results. If a number would help, ask me for it.

Step 5. After all 8, give me my 3 strongest answers, the 1 answer to practice most, and a 3-line cheat sheet to read right before the interview.

If I say "harder", ask the follow-up a skeptical interviewer would ask. If I say "skip", move on. If I say "again", let me retry. Start with Step 1.
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HOW TO GET THE MOST FROM IT

- **Answer out loud first, then type it.** Interviews are spoken. If it's too long to say, it's too long.
- **Say “harder”** after a good answer. You'll get the follow-up a skeptical interviewer asks.
- **Give it your real numbers.** It's told to never invent them, so the more you give, the stronger the rewrite.
- **Run it once per job.** The questions come from that specific job post, so every run is different.
- **Practice the weak answer, not the strong one.** The summary at the end tells you which.

Privacy tip: remove your street address and phone number from the resume before pasting it. The AI doesn't need them.

LEAVING AND LAYOFFS

1 Why did you leave your last job? (laid off)

My role was cut in a reduction in force that affected [how many people or which teams]. Before I left, I [best result with a number]. I want to do more of that, and this role caught my eye because [one thing from the job post].

Why it works: Say “not performance-based” only if it's true. Never criticize the old company.

2 Why were you the one let go?

I don't know the full criteria, and I won't guess. What I do know is what I delivered: [result]. My manager there, [title], is one of my references and can speak to it.

Why it works: Calm and short. Handing them a reference ends the topic.

3 Why are you leaving your current job?

I've [done X] there and learned a lot. The next thing I want is [scope this job has], and that isn't available on my team. This role has it.

Why it works: Pull toward the new job instead of pushing away from the old one.

4 Were you fired?

Yes. [One neutral sentence on what happened.] What I took from it is [specific change], and since then I've [proof the change stuck].

Why it works: Own it in one line, then spend the rest of the answer on what changed.

5 How do you feel about your last company?

Grateful. I worked on [project] and got good at [skill]. Layoffs are a business decision, and I'm focused on what's next.

Why it works: Even if you're angry, the interviewer hears how you'll talk about them one day.

6 Would you go back if they called?

I'm focused on roles that are a step forward, and this one is because [reason].

Why it works: Don't sound like they're your backup plan.

GAPS, AGE AND “OVERQUALIFIED”

7 Tell me about this gap.

After my role was cut in [month], I took [time] to [search carefully + one concrete thing: a course, certification, project, freelance work or family]. I finished [result]. I'm ready to be back full time, and I've been choosy about fit rather than taking the first offer.

Why it works: No apology. One sentence on why, one on what you did, one on being ready.

8 You seem overqualified for this.

I see why it looks that way. What I want is [the actual work in this role], not a bigger title. My experience means I've already seen [common problem in this role] and fixed it, so I'd be useful fast. What would make you confident I'd stay?

Why it works: The closing question brings their real worry into the open so you can answer it.

9 How would you feel reporting to someone with less experience?

Good managers are about clarity and support, not years. I've worked for people with less experience than me and learned from them. My job is to make my manager and the team look good.

Why it works: This is often the age question in disguise. Answer the job part only.

10 How do you keep your skills current?

Every week I [habit: course, newsletter, side project, AI tool]. Recently I learned [tool or skill] and used it to [result].

Why it works: One habit plus one recent proof beats a list of courses.

11 Why you over a cheaper, more junior candidate?

You'd get [years] of solving [problem this role has]. A junior hire learns that on your time. In my first 90 days I'd [concrete outcome].

Why it works: Talk about how fast you'd deliver. Leave salary out of it.

12 Where do you see yourself in five years?

Doing [this kind of work] at a bigger scale, ideally here. I want to be the person the team trusts with [hardest problem in the role].

Why it works: Show you'd stay and grow in the job, not leave it.

OPENING AND CLOSING

13 Tell me about yourself.

I'm a [title] with [X] years in [field]. Most recently I [best result with a number]. Before that, [one earlier proof]. Now I'm looking for [what this role offers], which is why I applied here.

Why it works: Present, past proof, future. Under 90 seconds. Skip your childhood and first job.

14 Why should we hire you?

You need [top requirement from the post]. I've done exactly that: [result]. You also need [second requirement], and I [proof]. In week one I'd start on [first priority].

Why it works: Use their words from the job post. Two proofs, one plan.

15 Why do you want to work here?

[Specific product, recent news or value from their site]. It connects to my work on [related experience]. And this role lets me do more [the work you want].

Why it works: If your answer could be about any company, it's too generic.

16 What's your greatest strength?

[Strength]. For example, when [situation], I [action], and [result with a number].

Why it works: A strength without a story doesn't stick. Always add the example.

17 What's your biggest weakness?

[A real weakness that isn't core to this job]. It used to cost me [effect]. Now I [system you use], and last quarter [proof it's better].

Why it works: “I work too hard” loses trust. A real weakness that's improving gains it.

18 Is there anything else we should know?

Just that I'm very interested. From what you've said, [problem they mentioned] is the priority, and I've solved that before: [one line]. What are the next steps?

Why it works: Use the last minute to repeat your best match and ask for the next step.

AI QUESTIONS

19 Do you have AI experience?

Yes. I use AI every week for [task], and it saves me about [time]. I still check every output, because [risk in your field].

Why it works: Not true yet? Use the mock-interviewer prompt on your own job description and do one real task this week.

20 Why should we hire you if AI can do this job?

AI can draft the work. I decide what's right, catch what it gets wrong, and get people to act on it. For example, [real example].

Why it works: Don't argue that AI is bad. Show what you do that it can't.

21 How do you use AI in your work?

Three ways: drafting [doc type], analyzing [data type], and prepping for [meetings or reviews]. Last month it helped me [result]. I keep confidential data out of tools my company hasn't approved.

Why it works: The data line tells them you're safe to give access to.

22 What are the risks of AI?

It can sound confident when it's wrong, and it can leak data if people are careless. So I treat it like a fast junior helper: clear instructions, check the work, keep sensitive data out.

Why it works: Balanced answers beat both hype and fear.

23 How would you use AI in this role?

In my first month I'd find the repetitive part of [role task], like [example], and test whether AI can draft it. If it saves time without hurting quality, I'd share the steps with the team.

Why it works: A small, safe pilot sounds like someone they can trust.

24 Will AI replace your job?

Parts of it, like [starter task]. The parts that are growing are [judgment, people or decision tasks], and that's where I spend my time.

Why it works: Name the growing parts. They're your best resume bullets.

BEHAVIORAL STORIES (STAR IN 4 LINES)

25 Tell me about a time you failed.

Situation: [one sentence]. My part: [what you owned]. What I did: [2-3 actions, including what you changed after]. Result: [what happened next, with a number if you have one].

Why it works: Pick a real failure from a few years ago that you fixed. The fix is the point.

26 Tell me about a conflict with a coworker.

Situation: [disagreement about the work, not their personality]. What I did: I [asked to talk 1:1], [found the shared goal], [agreed a plan]. Result: [delivered X], and we still [work well together].

Why it works: Never make the other person the villain.

27 A time you disagreed with your manager.

I disagreed with [decision] because [data]. I brought it to them privately with [evidence]. [They changed course / we went with their call and I committed fully]. Result: [outcome].

Why it works: Either ending works. Disagree with data, then commit.

28 A time you had a tight deadline.

We had [time] to deliver [thing]. I [cut scope with the stakeholder], [split the work], [checked in daily]. We shipped [on date], [result].

Why it works: Show that you planned it. Don't make it sound like you just worked harder.

29 A time you led without authority.

I needed [team] to [do X] but didn't manage them. I [showed what was in it for them], [made it easy], [shared credit]. Result: [number].

Why it works: Program and project people: this is your strongest story.

30 A time you made a mistake.

I [mistake]. I caught it [when], told [who] right away, and [fixed it]. Since then I [check you added]. It hasn't happened again.

Why it works: Speed of owning it matters more than the mistake.

31 How did you handle a big change or reorg?

When [change] happened, I [got clear on new priorities], [helped the team adjust], and [kept X on track]. Result: [number].

Why it works: After a layoff, this question is about whether you'll stay steady.

32 What's your proudest accomplishment?

[Project] at [company]. The challenge was [hard part]. I [your actions]. It [result with number], and it still [lasting effect].

Why it works: Pick one tied to what this job needs, not just your biggest one.

SALARY AND OFFERS

33 What are your salary expectations?

I'd like to learn more about the role first. Could you share the budgeted range? — If pushed: “Based on [source] for this role in [location], I'm targeting [range], with my number at the bottom of it.”

Why it works: Look up the range before the call. Many job posts now list it.

34 What were you making at your last job?

I'd rather focus on the value of this role. My target is [range].

Why it works: Many US states and cities bar employers from asking. You don't have to answer.

35 Responding to a low offer.

Thank you, I'm excited about this. Based on [scope or market data], I was expecting closer to [number]. Is there flexibility on base, or on [sign-on bonus, PTO, start date, title]?

Why it works: Ask once, politely, with a number. Then stop talking.

36 Are you interviewing anywhere else?

Yes, I'm talking with a few companies. This one is high on my list because [reason].

Why it works: Honest and brief. A little competition helps you.

YOUR QUESTIONS FOR THEM

37 What would make someone great in this role at 90 days?

Ask it, then repeat back how you'd hit it.

Why it works: It tells you exactly what to promise in your thank-you note.

38 What's the first problem this hire needs to solve?

Ask it, then share a one-line example of solving something similar.

Why it works: It turns the rest of the interview into a working conversation.

39 How has the team been affected by recent changes, and what's the outlook?

Ask it calmly. Listen for whether the role is funded and stable.

Why it works: After a layoff, you're allowed to check the floor is solid.

40 Is there anything about my background that makes you hesitate?

Ask it near the end, then answer whatever they say with one proof.

Why it works: The bravest question, and the one that saves the most offers.

RECRUITER-CALL SCRIPT (15-MINUTE SCREEN)

Open (10 sec)	Hi [name], thanks for calling. I've got the job post in front of me and I'm excited to talk.
Your pitch (30 sec)	Short version of “Tell me about yourself”: title, years, best result, why this role.
Ask them	What's the budgeted range? What are the interview steps and timeline? What does the hiring manager care about most? Why is the role open?
If salary comes up	Ask for their range first. If pushed, give your researched range with your target at the bottom.
Close	Based on what you've shared, I'm a strong fit because [one line]. What are the next steps, and when should I expect to hear?
After	Thank-you email within 2 hours. One line on the role's top need and how you'd meet it.

THE NIGHT BEFORE

☐ Re-read the job post and highlight its top 3 needs.

☐ Run the mock interviewer once more, on the hardest question only.

☐ Say your “Tell me about yourself” out loud twice. Time it.

☐ Pick 3 stories, each with one real number, and match each to a top need.

☐ Write your 2 questions for them on a sticky note.

☐ Look up the interviewers on LinkedIn: role, time at the company, one thing in common.

☐ Video call: test camera, mic and lighting. Close other apps. Plug in.

☐ In person: plan the route and leave 20 minutes early.

☐ Have the resume version you applied with open, so your numbers match.

☐ Sleep. A rested 7 beats a tired 9.

Want a second pair of eyes? The AI Career Firewall Audit: send your resume and LinkedIn, and I send back a 1-page layoff-readiness plan and 5 AI prompts written for your job, within 48 hours. $39 at buy.stripe.com/3cI00ldx57fS0IM7K108g00.

Free prompts from every video: github.com/jmontanez/career-firewall-media. Questions or problems with your kit: theaicareerfirewall@gmail.com.